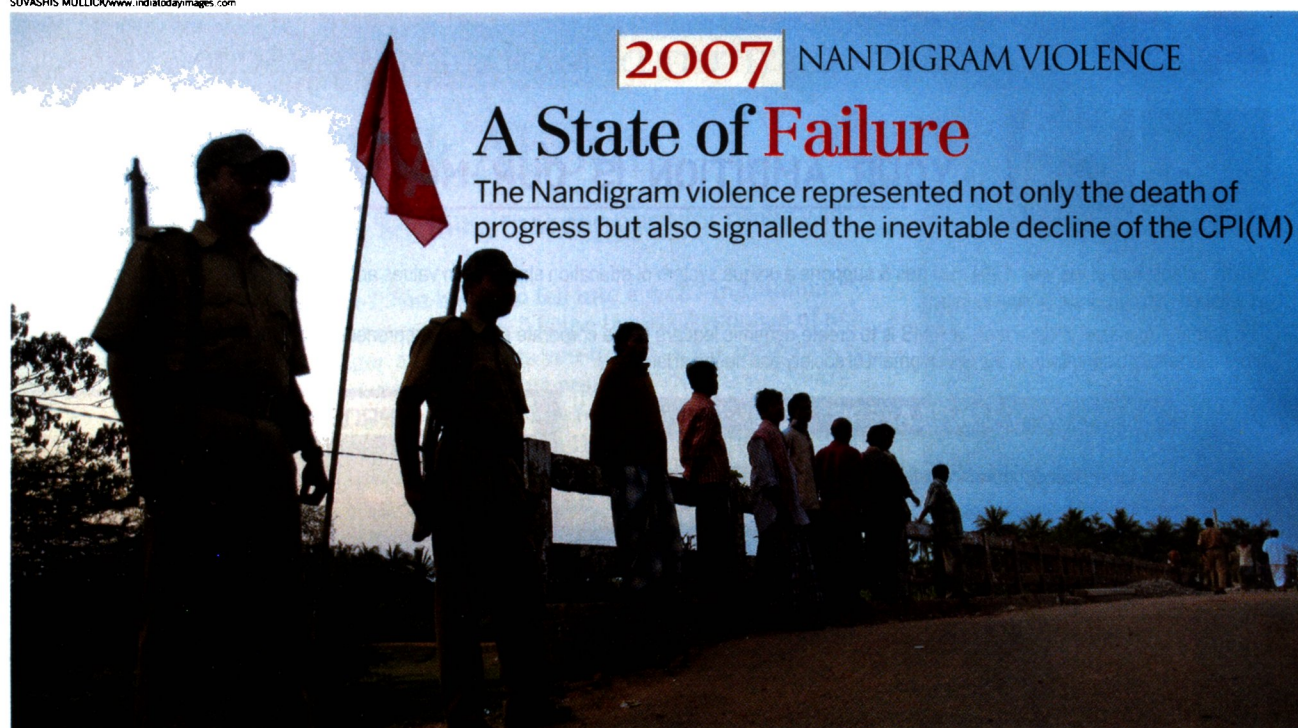




2007 NANDIGRAM VIOLENCE

A State of Failure

The Nandigram violence represented not only the death of progress but also signalled the inevitable decline of the CPI(M)

In 2007, on paper, Nandigram was the closest police station to 11 months of civil war-like condition on 27,000 acres of land housing over 100 villages in the East Midnapore district of West Bengal. But it was the metaphorical Nandigram that mattered, in which it wasn't just people who died, but also the dream of progress and the promise of industrialisation. Riding high on the Left Government's 30 years of state rule, Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya was on a mission to industrialise. Having convinced Ratan Tata to set up his Nano project in Singur, he promised the state's largest SEZ, with an investment of Rs 48,000 crore, to be set up with an Indonesian real-estate giant, the Salim Group. But to avoid the trouble it faced in setting up the Nano project, when the opposition leader, Trinamool Congress's firebrand Mamata Banerjee, fasted through December 2006 stalling the factory's construction, the Left decided to set up the Salim SEZ in Nandigram, it being a Left stronghold. On January 2, farmers, with the help of Trinamool activists, clashed with 250 CPI(M) cadres after getting a letter on land acquisition from CPI(M) MP Lakshman Seth. Six people died in the clash and the farmers blocked the area earmarked for the SEZ. Till March, they would not allow a single "outsider" to enter Nandigram, be it the police or government officials. On March 14, Bhattacharya sent 2,500 policemen to "recapture" Nandigram, but unofficially, they were accompanied by suspected 400 CPI(M) cadres. Officially, 14 farmers died in the firing, but over 100 were declared "missing". A similar attempt in November by the cadres finally "re-

captured" Nandigram. Bhattacharya showed no remorse as he said, "They (farmers and Trinamool activists) have been paid back in their own coin." It has mostly been pay-back time for him since then. While the Left lost its credibility in the state, Banerjee went on to form an alliance with the Congress. The Nandigram MP is now from Banerjee's party. The Salim SEZ still hasn't seen the light of day, while the Nano is being manufactured out of Sanand, Gujarat. And the Union government has declared a new set of laws and land reforms where SEZs are concerned. Just so no one dies to build a factory.

by Swagata Sen

THE MAIN EVENT

Sensex Crosses 20K

Figures can be as eloquent as pictures, worth a thousand words. India Rising is a story best told through numbers. Indian corporates have set and broken new records. For over 19 quarters—nearly five years—corporates have sustained a 30-plus per cent rise in profits, fuelling the biggest bull run ever in Indian stocks. In just one year, the BSE Sensex rose from 14,000 to 20,000, adding 6,000 points in 249 trading sessions. The fact that it took the Sensex five years to move from 5,000 to 10,000 may help put the altitude in perspective.

India Today, January 14, 2008

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